

Introduction of RDTII Framework

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Agenda

What is RDTII 2.1

- Scope: 12 policy Pillars, 3 Clusters
- Where: Asia - Pacific region
- How: Process of data collection
 - Policy Measures Coverage
 - ICT products and/or digital services
 - Official sources & exceptions
 - Vertical and horizontal measures
 - Scoring criteria
 - Practical applications
 - Online portal
 - Knowledge products

What is RDTII 2.1?

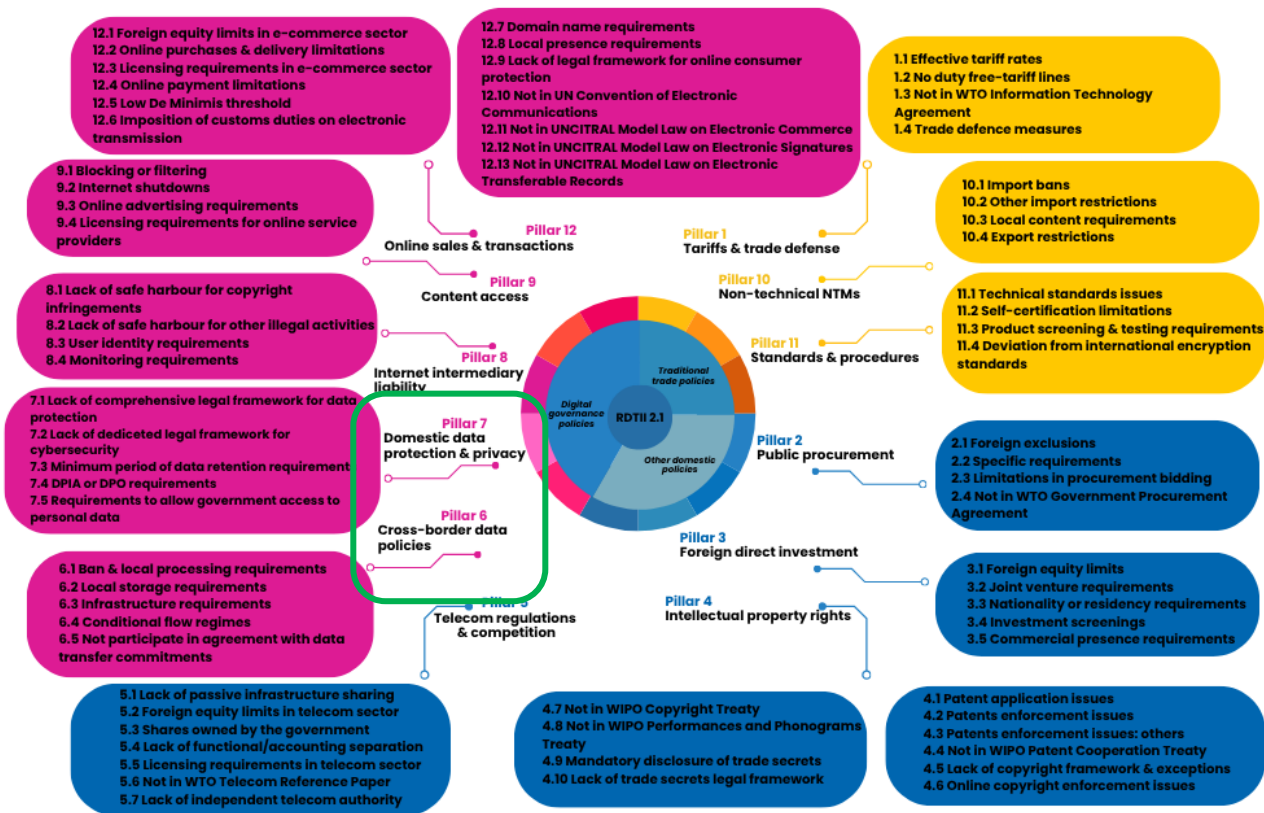
Regional Digital Trade Integration Index (RDTII) is a proxy for digital economy integration in terms of the openness and harmonization of the regulatory environment for digital trade in the region.

- **12 policy areas “Pillars” → 69 “Policy Indicators”**
- **3 Clusters:**
 - **Traditional measures cluster**
 - **Other domestic regulations cluster**
 - **Digital governance measures cluster**
- **Score 0 to 1: 0 (minimal) 1 (extensive): Score to represent approaches, not a value judgement**
- **48 Asia-Pacific economies: coverage still expanding (130+ economies globally including Asia-Pacific, Africa, Latin American & Caribbean)**

The index degree is intended to flag complexity created by digital trade regulations, which often go beyond trade barriers.

The framework does not capture the full range of social, economic, security and environmental concerns that may need to be considered when engaging in the regulatory reform.

Scope: 12 Policy areas (“Pillars”) relevant to digital trade



RDTII Cluster 1

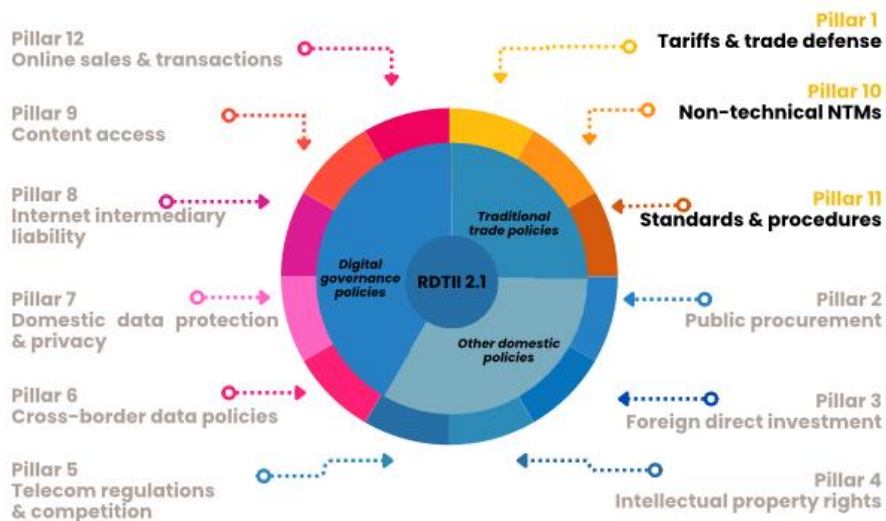
Traditional (trade) measures



Traditional policies

Other domestic policies

Digital governance



- 1.1 Effective tariff rates
- 1.2 No duty-free tariff lines
- 1.3 Not in WTO Information Technology Agreement
- 1.4 Trade defence measures

- 10.1 Import bans
- 10.2 Other import restrictions
- 10.3 Local content requirements
- 10.4 Export restrictions

- 11.1 Technical standards issues
- 11.2 Self-certification limitations
- 11.3 Product screening & testing requirements
- 11.4 Deviation from international encryption standards

Policies affecting the cost and ease of moving hardware, software, and related services across borders



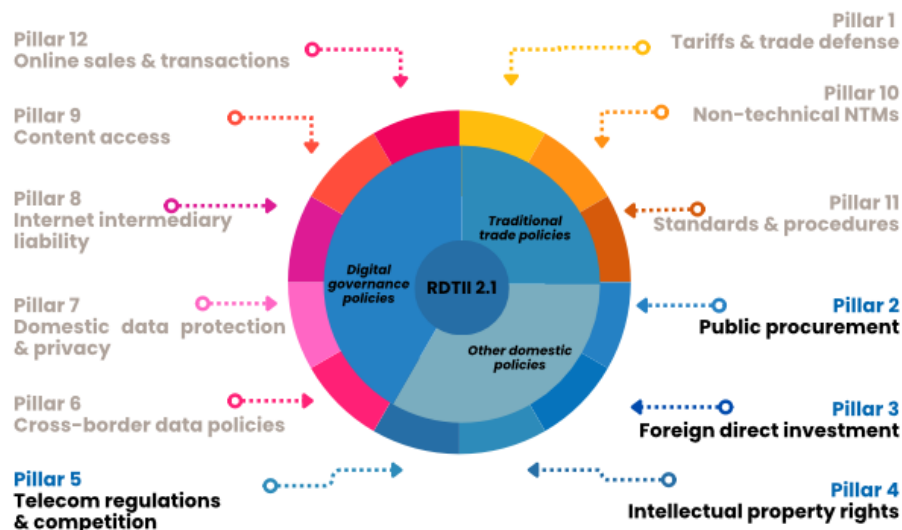
RDTII Cluster 2

Other domestic policies

Traditional policies

Other domestic policies

Digital governance



- 2.1 Foreign exclusions
- 2.2 Specific requirements
- 2.3 Limitations in procurement bidding
- 2.4 Not in WTO Government Procurement Agreement

- 3.1 Foreign equity limits
- 3.2 Joint venture requirements
- 3.3 Nationality or residency requirements
- 3.4 Investment screenings
- 3.5 Commercial presence requirements

- 5.1 Lack of passive infrastructure sharing
- 5.2 Foreign equity limits in telecom sector
- 5.3 Shares owned by the government
- 5.4 Lack of functional/accounting separation
- 5.5 Licensing requirements in telecom sector
- 5.6 Not in WTO Telecom Reference Paper
- 5.7 Lack of independent telecom authority

- 4.1 Online copyright enforcement issues
- 4.2 Not in WIPO Copyright Treaty
- 4.3 Not in WIPO Performances and Phonograms Treaty
- 4.4 Mandatory disclosure of trade secrets
- 4.5 Lack of trade secrets legal framework
- 4.6 Patent application issues
- 4.7 Patents enforcement issues
- 4.8 Patents enforcement issues: others
- 4.9 Not in WIPO Patent Cooperation Treaty
- 4.10 Lack of copyright framework & exceptions

Policies influence who can operate in a market, and level playing field



RDTII Cluster 3

Digital governance policies

Traditional policies

Other domestic policies

Digital governance



Pillar 12
Online sales & transactions

Pillar 9
Content access

Pillar 8
Internet intermediary liability

Pillar 7
Domestic data protection & privacy

Pillar 6
Cross-border data policies

Pillar 5
Telecom regulations & competition

Pillar 10
Tariffs & trade defense

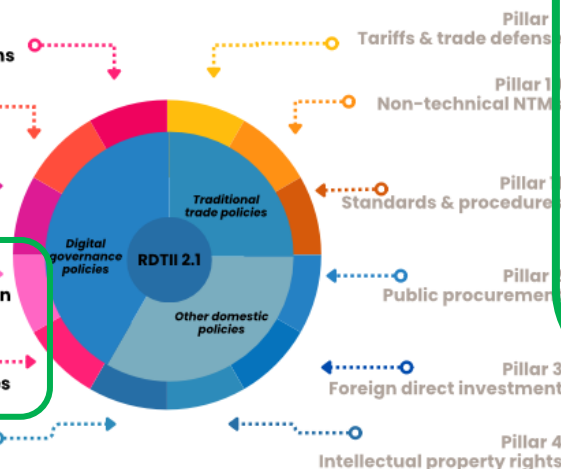
Pillar 11
Non-technical NTMs

Pillar 1
Standards & procedures

Pillar 2
Public procurement

Pillar 3
Foreign direct investment

Pillar 4
Intellectual property rights



- 6.1 Ban & local processing requirements
- 6.2 Local storage requirements
- 6.3 Infrastructure requirements
- 6.4 Conditional flow regimes
- ~~6.5 Not participate in agreement with data transfer commitments~~

- 7.1 Lack of comprehensive legal framework for data protection
- 7.2 Lack of dedicated legal framework for cybersecurity
- 7.3 Minimum period of data retention requirements
- 7.4 DPIA or DPO requirements
- 7.5 Requirements to allow government access to personal data

- 8.1 Lack of safe harbour for copyright infringements
- 8.2 Lack of safe harbour for other illegal activities
- 8.3 User identity requirements
- 8.4 Monitoring requirements

- 9.1 Blocking or filtering
- 9.2 Internet shutdowns
- 9.3 Online advertising requirements
- 9.4 Licensing requirements for online service providers

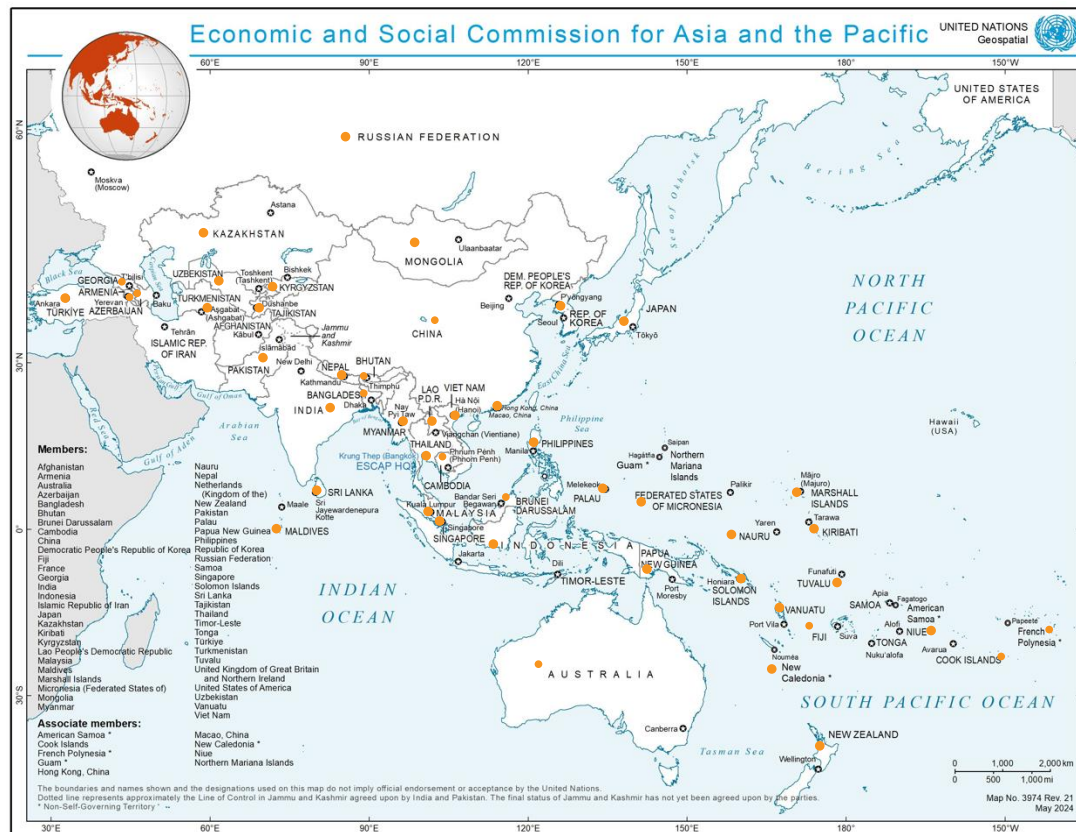
- 12.1 Foreign equity limits in e-commerce sector
- 12.2 Online purchases & delivery limitations
- 12.3 Licensing requirements in e-commerce sector
- 12.4 Online payment limitations
- 12.5 Low De Minimis threshold
- 12.6 Imposition of custom duties on electronic transmission
- 12.7 Domain name requirements
- 12.8 Local presence requirements
- 12.9 Lack of legal framework for online consumer protection
- 12.10 Not in UN Convention of Electronic Communications
- 12.11 Not in UNCITRAL Model Law on Electronic Commerce
- 12.12 Not in UNCITRAL Model Law on Electronic Signatures
- 12.13 Not in UNCITRAL Model Law on Electronic Transferable Records

Policies shaping digital services, e-commerce, and digital firms



Where: Asia and the Pacific

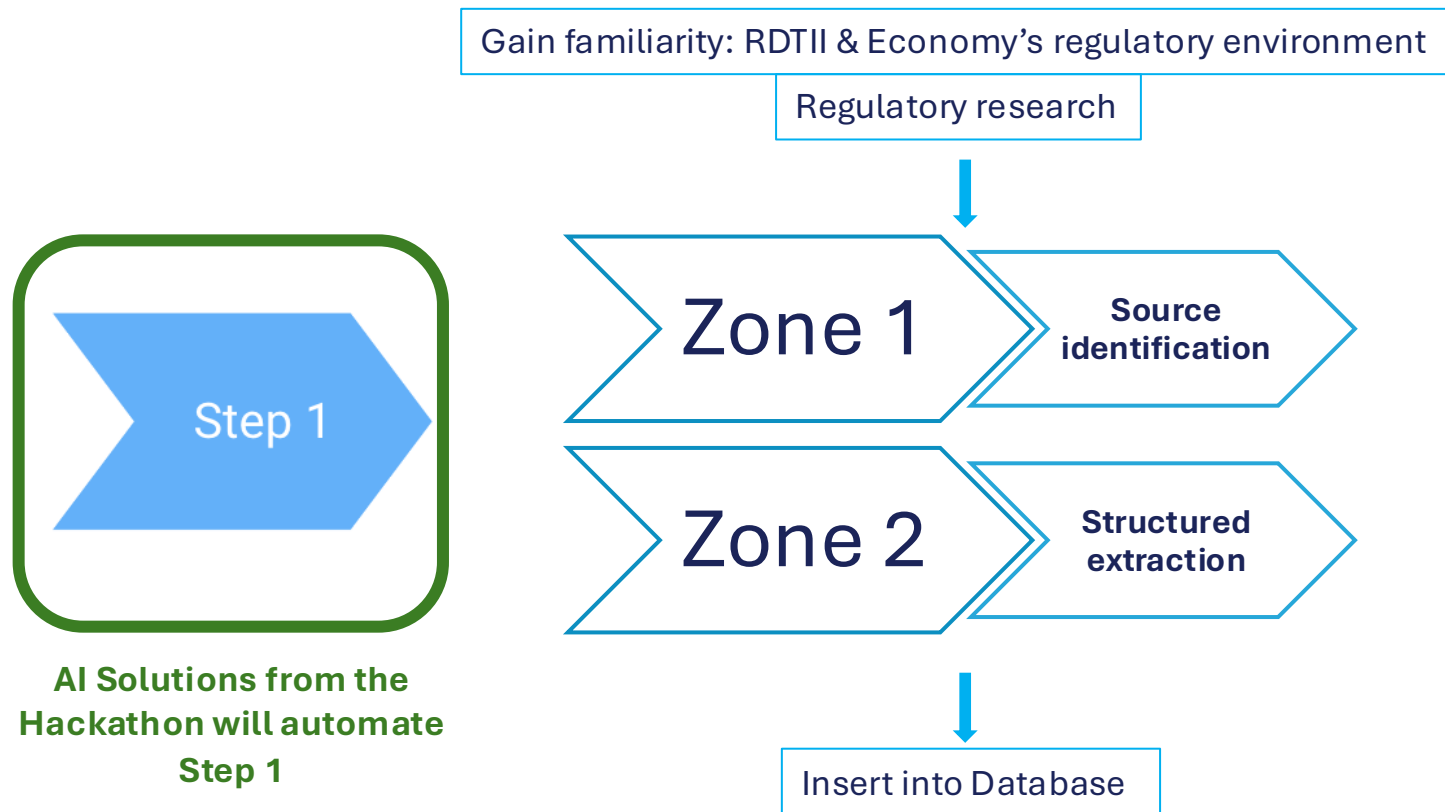
- As of June 2026, the ESCAP database tracks **48** Asia-Pacific economies (orange dots) that are members and associate members of ESCAP. The list of coverage has grown overtime.



Current ESCAP process for RDTII database



How: Current manual process for data collection



Gain familiarity with RDTII

1. RDTII Policy Measure Coverage

- 1) Measures affecting digital trade-related products and services.
- 2) Non-preferential and enforced measures from official sources, focusing on domestic and international frameworks.
- 3) Horizontal and vertical measures.
- 4) Scoring criteria.

2. Practical applications

- 1) Online portal
- 2) Knowledge products

Policy Measure Coverage

1. Measures affecting digital trade-related products and services
2. Non-preferential and enforced measures from official sources, focusing on domestic and international frameworks.
3. Horizontal and vertical measures.
4. Scoring criteria

1. Measures affecting digital trade-related products and services

- **Digital trade** includes:
 - **Digitally ordered trade:** international sales or purchases of goods and/or services conducted over computer networks
 - **Digitally delivered trade:** international service transactions delivered remotely over computer networks
- **ICT products:** goods used to capture, transmit, process, and render information
 - ITA I, ITA II, ITA III
 - ITA III list purposed by the Information Technology and Innovation Foundation (ITIF) including next generation ICT products (e.g., 3D printing, drones, and robots).
 - **Raw materials** such as rare earth, used in the production of the ICT products, are not covered in the current RDTII framework.
 - **E-waste and used ICT products** will not assign a score.
- **Digital products / digital goods:** intangible products created and delivered digitally
- **Digital services:** services delivered via digital means
- **Excludes:**
 - regulations on **non-commercial services**
 - regulations applying **only to offline versions**



2. Non-preferential and enforced measures from official sources

- **Non-preferential measure**
 - Covers domestic regulations and specific international frameworks
 - Excludes preferential trade agreement provisions
- **Enforced measure**
 - Excludes pending draft and repealed measures
- **Official sources**
 - Covers official laws, regulations, guidelines, government decisions, case laws, etc.
 - Excludes secondary sources (reports, news, and legal reviews).

• **! Exception:**

- Sub-pilar focuses on enforcement and practices (Indicator 3.4, 5.3, 9.1)
- Calculations of tariffs on imported ICT products: WITS database ~~(Indicator 1.1, 1.2)~~
- Presence of the Internet shutdowns: V-Dem database ~~(Indicator 9.2)~~
- International/Regional Instruments engagement: Third-party website ~~(Indicator 1.3, 2.4, 4.4, 4.7, 4.8, 5.6, 6.5, 12.10, 12.11, 12.12, 12.13)~~

No need to develop data-extraction tools, as the relevant data is sourced from established third-party databases and websites.

The Non-regulatory indicators list is provided in the knowledge portal, removed from the sample database provided.



3. Horizontal and vertical measures

- **Vertical Coverage**

- Encompasses all levels of legal hierarchy, from overarching laws (Acts) to supplementary regulations (decrees, decisions, etc.).

- **Horizontal Coverage**

- Includes laws with broad application across sectors (e.g., Public Procurement Act, Foreign Business Act).
- Sector-specific regulations apply to telecom, computer, e-commerce, etc.

Note: Each indicator has a specific scope and exception.

E.g., Pillar 6 (cross-border data policies), measures applied to government data should not get scored.



4. Scoring criteria

- **A score more than “0”**
- High compliance costs
- **A score of “0”**
- Low compliance costs
- Absence of specific measures/ regulations
 - Citing relevant general rules (if have)
 - State the reason in the 'Impact' column.

The score runs from ‘0’ (low compliance cost) to ‘1’ (high compliance cost)

A score which is greater than ‘0’ indicates one of the following

1. A measure implies a **differential treatment** between domestic and foreign providers of ICT goods, online services, digitally-delivered products despite being in the same or similar circumstances.
2. A measure aims to achieve a non-economic objective but ends up **blocks or discourages foreign and local businesses** from participating in digital trade in the regulating economy.
3. An economy **fails to adopt a certain international agreement**, legislation, or legal mechanism considered of significant importance for the development of digital trade



RDTII Practical applications

Online portal: <https://www.unescap.org/projects/rcdtra>



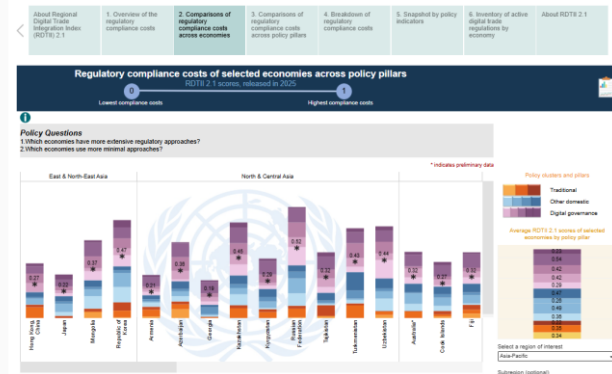
ESCAP Initiative on Regional Digital Trade Integration

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Regional Digital Trade Integration Index dashboard

This dashboard provides a visual illustration of data from the Regional Digital Trade Integration Index (RDTII) and the Digital Trade Regulatory Similarity (DTRS). It offers an overview of digital trade regulatory landscapes, allowing users to explore data within and across the Asia-Pacific, Africa, and Latin America and the Caribbean regions.

For the best experience, please use full-screen mode. Click on the full-screen icon at the bottom right of the dashboard.



RDTII 2.1 Regulatory Database

The database compiles an inventory of currently active digital trade related regulations across economies, structured under the Regional Digital Trade Integration Index (RDTII) framework.

Complexity of Act or Practice (Based on RDTII score)									
COMPLEX			LESS COMPLEX						
Economy			Policy Pillar		Policy Indicator		Coverage		
All			All		All		All		
Economy	Policy Pillar	Policy Indicator	Act and/or practice		Coverage	Complexity of Act or Practice	Timeframe	URL1	URL2
Armenia	1.Tariffs and Trade Defence	1.1 Effective tariff rates (%)	Effectively applied tariffs on ICT goods (in weighted average) imported from other economies within the considered United Nations region (%)		ICT products	The effectively applied tariff on ICT goods imported from Asia-Pacific is below 10% (1.81%).	Since 2021		
Armenia	1.Tariffs and Trade Defence	1.2 No duty-free tariff lines (%)	No duty-free tariff lines on ICT goods from other economies within the considered United Nations region (%)		ICT products	Duty-free tariff lines cover 58.8% of ICT goods imported from Asia-Pacific economies.	Since 2021		
Armenia	1.Tariffs and Trade Defence	1.3 Not in WTO Information Technology Agreement (ITA) and in ITA Expansion Agreement (ITA II)	Lack of Participation in Information Technology Agreement (ITA) and in ITA Expansion Agreement (ITA II)		Digital goods covered by the ITA	Lack of Participation in Information Technology Agreement (ITA) and in ITA Expansion Agreement (ITA II)	Last reviewed in October 2024		
Armenia has fulfilled the necessary internal procedures on according to the WTO Information Technology Agreement (ITA II). An international agreement signed or subject to accession by the Republic of Armenia under RA Law on International Agreements shall become binding on the Republic of Armenia through ratification by the National Assembly of the Republic of Armenia or approval of the President of the Republic. At the moment, it is in the process of finishing the necessary domestic procedures.									
Armenia	1.Tariffs and Trade Defence	1.4 Trade defence	Decision of the EEC Board No. 115 : Product: aluminum alloy		Product: aluminum alloy	Since October 2020, the Eurasian	Since October 2020		

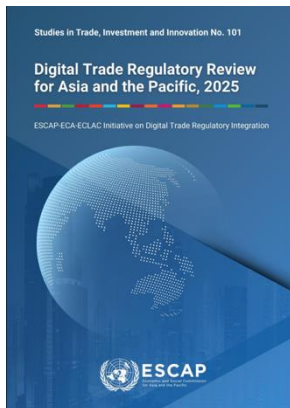
ECA-ECLAC-ESCAP Portal



- The portal provides access to digital trade regulatory data based on two indexes:
 - RDTII 2.1 Dashboard and Database
 - Partner indices.
- It covers Asia-Pacific 48 economy datasets. These digital trade regulatory indexes are tools for policymakers, practitioners, and policy analysts to assess the digital trade policy landscape in Asia-Pacific

RDTII Practical applications

Knowledge Products & National Action Plans



Knowledge products, such as:

- Digital trade regulatory reviews (latest 2025) Regional and Subregional
- Taking stock of the digital trade and investment policies in the Asia-Pacific Region with ESCAP's Regional Digital Trade Integration Index
- Economy profiles (48 economies individual policy landscape)

National action plans:

- A roadmap that helps a country assess its current regulatory and digital trade environment, identify gaps and barriers, and set out concrete actions to improve digital trade infrastructure, policies, and regulations
- Pakistan, Philippines, Kazakhstan, Mongolia

➤ Next

- How RDTII researchers analyse, identify, extract, classify, and score legal provisions in practice when collecting RDTII data manually.
- Challenges and difficulties encountered by researchers, and how these were addressed.

THANK YOU!



More on RDTII

For any queries reach at juntong.hou@un.org, or hackathon email: escap-digitaltrade-hackathon@un.org